

Art by Gene Colan & Frank Giacoia, from *Iron Man #1* (May 1968)

Iron Man first appeared in the March 1963 issue of *Tales of Suspense*, #39, with a cover trumpeting the arrival of a metal-clad monster that "Lives! Walks! And Conquers!" Longtime readers of the title would have been excused for thinking Iron Man was simply the latest creature feature in the book's usual retinue of shambling swamp beasts and menacing space aliens. But while his first story may have been a concise 13-pager in a fading monster mag, Iron Man's debut was a scintillating blockbuster for all time.

In that inaugural story, we meet the titular character and his alter ego, weapons developer Tony Stark. A brash and debonair multimillionaire — in today's money, a multibillionaire — Stark was without peer as the most sophisticated of all Marvel's leading men. But underneath this sophistication lay a factor common in Stan Lee's characters: an all-too human frailty. Spider-Man's weakness was his overwhelming guilt, while life with the Fantastic Four was fraught with interminable family squabbling. Meanwhile, Daredevil leaped across the rooftops of Hell's Kitchen while 100 percent blind. Tony Stark's weakness was his heart. A bum ticker that would have been a death sentence if not for his unmatched ingenuity.

How it got to be that way is the cornerstone of one of Marvel's most engrossing origin stories: While on a campaign to market a new line of weapons to U.S. military commanders in Vietnam, Stark is knocked for a loop by an enemy landmine. A piece of shrapnel wedged near his heart draws ever closer with each beat. Forced into servitude by the tyrannical camp commander and made to build a weapon that can be used against American forces, Stark surreptitiously crafts the life-saving armor that will help him — and his fellow prisoner, Yinsen — keep the shrapnel at bay and allow them to escape. Though not able



Art by Gene Colan & Gary Michaels, from *Tales of Suspense #78* (June 1966)